

01

The King's Indian from First Principles

Why Black concedes space and how the counterattack is justified



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

Understand the opening as a chain of decisions instead of a mysterious attacking ritual.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate Black's candidates, find White's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 001 | PAGE 4

Decode: The compact shell

The shell is only the launch platform; the break is the opening.

LESSON 002 | PAGE 8

Play: The compact shell

The shell is only the launch platform; the break is the opening.

LESSON 003 | PAGE 12

Decode: The classical closed center

Closed chains point the wings, but tempi decide the race.

LESSON 004 | PAGE 16

Play: The classical closed center

Closed chains point the wings, but tempi decide the race.

LESSON 005 | PAGE 20

Decode: The flank challenge with c5

Name the resulting structure before choosing the plan.

LESSON 006 | PAGE 24

Play: The flank challenge with c5

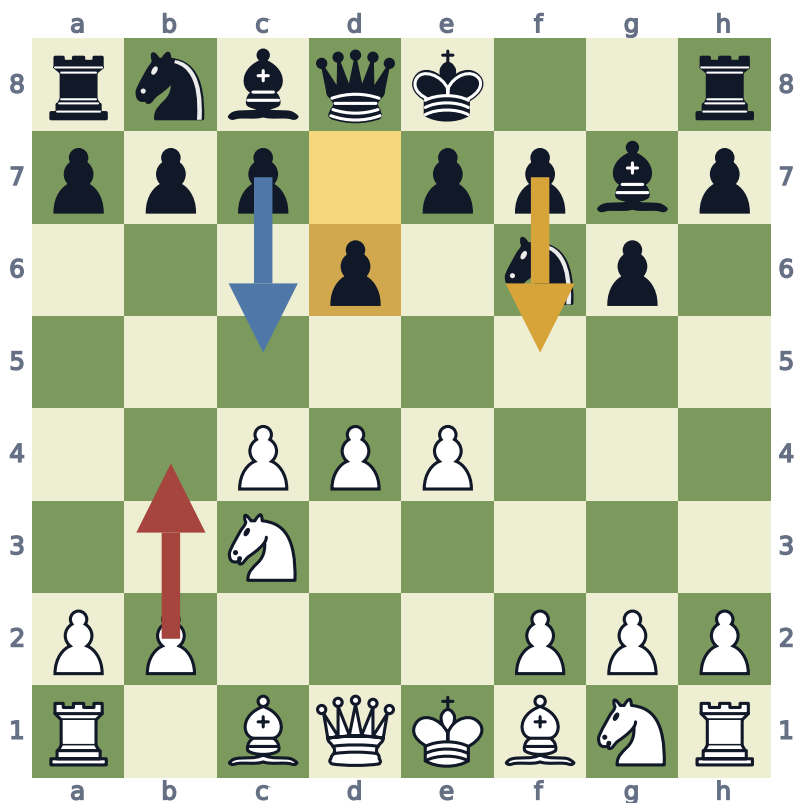
Name the resulting structure before choosing the plan.

VOLUME OBJECTIVE

Understand the opening as a chain of decisions instead of a mysterious attacking ritual.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The compact shell

**WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS**

Black lets White occupy the center because the pawns can become targets and because development is completed without fixing the central structure too soon.

DECISION RULE

Decide whether the next useful act is ...e5, ...c5, or a preparation that makes one break sound.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Castle, watch e5 and c5, and keep every piece connected to a future break.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White wants to stabilize e4 and d4, finish development, and use the extra space without creating hooks.

MEMORY RULE | The shell is only the launch platform; the break is the opening.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black lets White occupy the center because the pawns can become targets and because development is completed without fixing the central structure too soon.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Castle, watch e5 and c5, and keep every piece connected to a future break.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White wants to stabilize e4 and d4, finish development, and use the extra space without creating hooks.

FAILURE MODE

Copying the setup without challenging the center leaves Black cramped for no compensation.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Decide whether the next useful act is ...e5, ...c5, or a preparation that makes one break sound. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

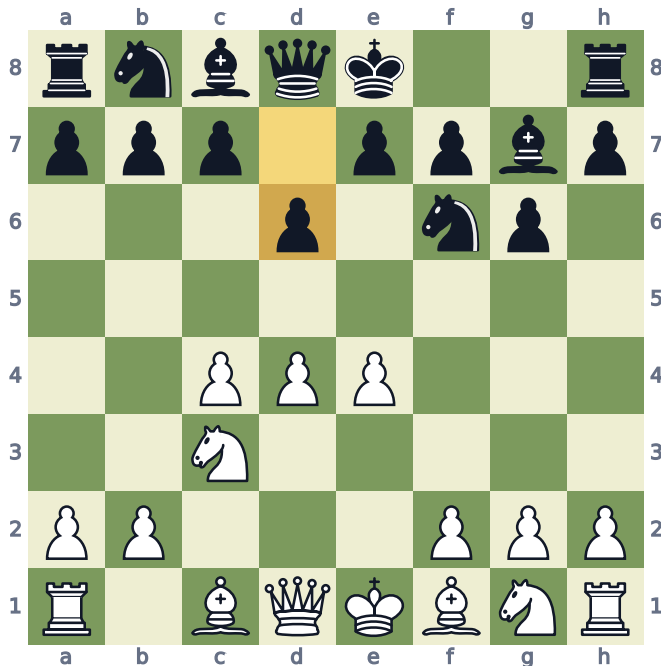
RULE | The shell is only the launch platform; the break is the opening.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2



- c4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- g6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- Nc3: White reroutes a knight toward c3; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- Bg7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- e4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black lets White occupy the center because the pawns can become targets and because development is completed without fixing the central structure too soon.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Decide whether the next useful act is ...e5, ...c5, or a preparation that makes one break sound. White's resistance is: White wants to stabilize e4 and d4, finish development, and use the extra space without creating hooks. The line fails as a template when: Copying the setup without challenging the center leaves Black cramped for no compensation.

STORE THIS | The shell is only the launch platform; the break is the opening.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

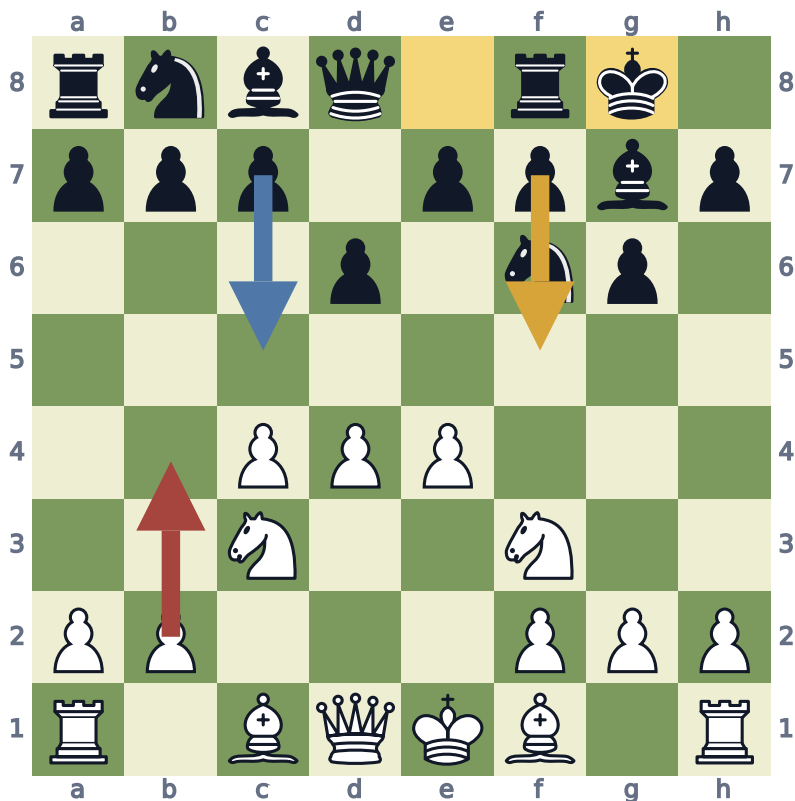
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 8 plies from memory, then replay: 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The compact shell



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black lets White occupy the center because the pawns can become targets and because development is completed without fixing the central structure too soon.

DECISION RULE

Decide whether the next useful act is ...e5, ...c5, or a preparation that makes one break sound.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

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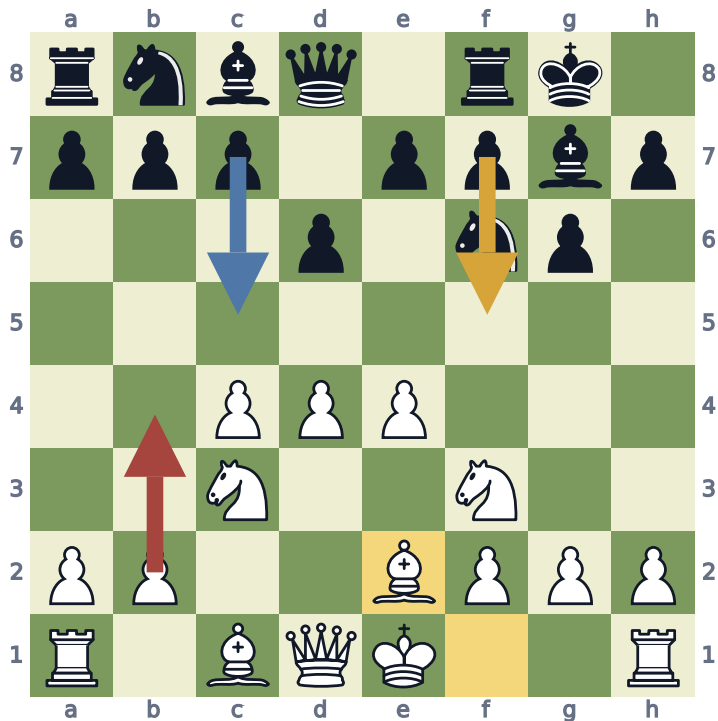
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The plan map



CUE

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BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

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FAILURE MODE

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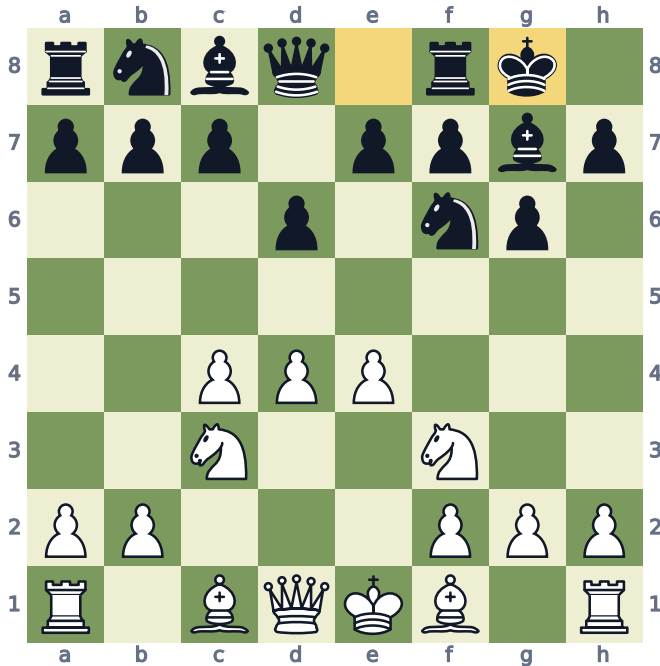
RULE | The shell is only the launch platform; the break is the opening.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

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- Nc3: White reroutes a knight toward c3; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- Bg7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- e4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- Nf3: White reroutes a knight toward f3; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.

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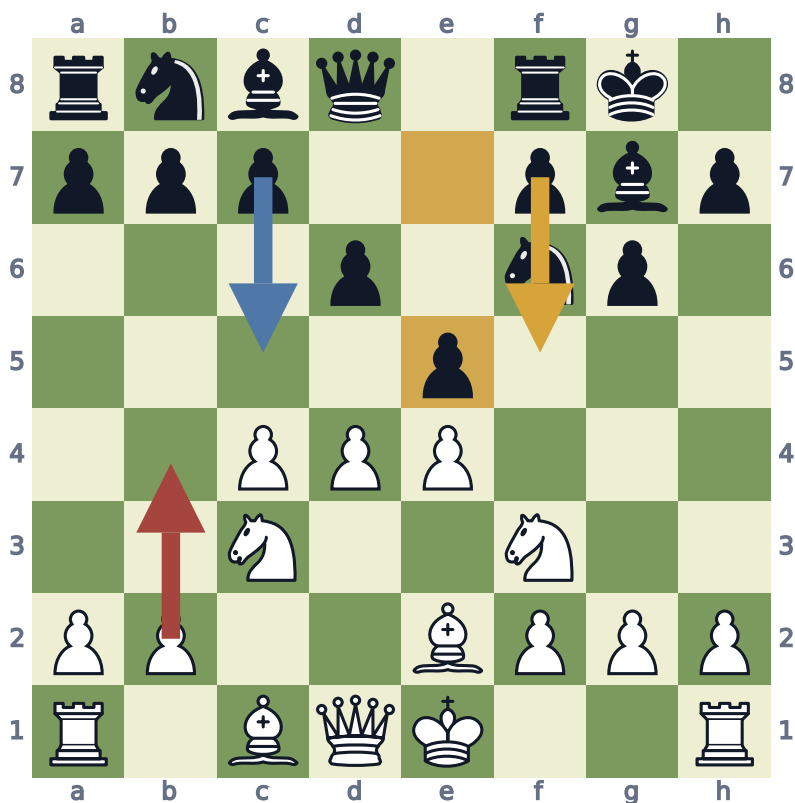
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 10 plies from memory, then replay: 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The classical closed center



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

After d5 the center becomes a directional map: White normally expands on the queenside while Black prepares kingside play.

DECISION RULE

Compare the speed of ...f5 with White's c5 break and change plans if the center can reopen.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Re-route the f6-knight, prepare ...f5, and count the race before pushing pawns.

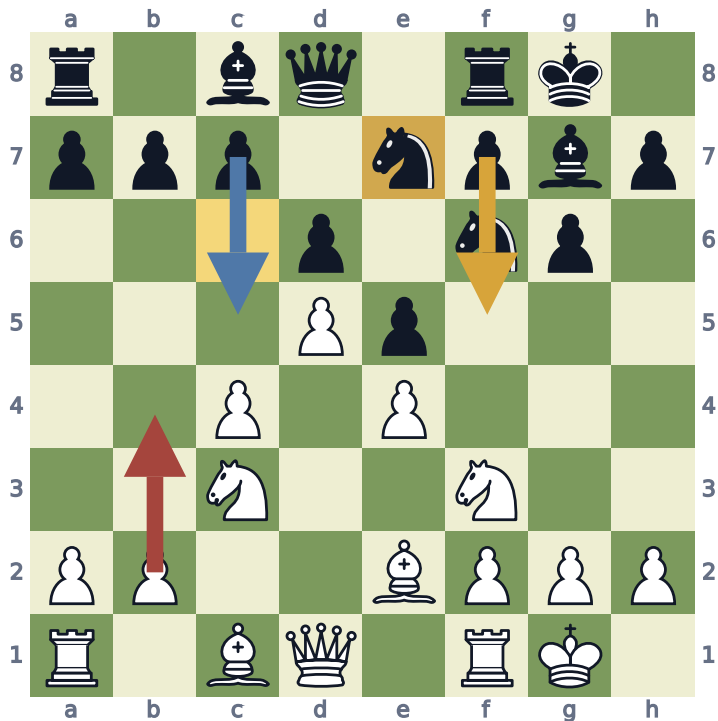
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White seeks c5, b4, and pressure against c7 or d6.

MEMORY RULE | Closed chains point the wings, but tempi decide the race.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

After d5 the center becomes a directional map: White normally expands on the queenside while Black prepares kingside play.

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

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FAILURE MODE

A kingside pawn storm is unsound when White can open the center against Black's king first.

DECISION TEST

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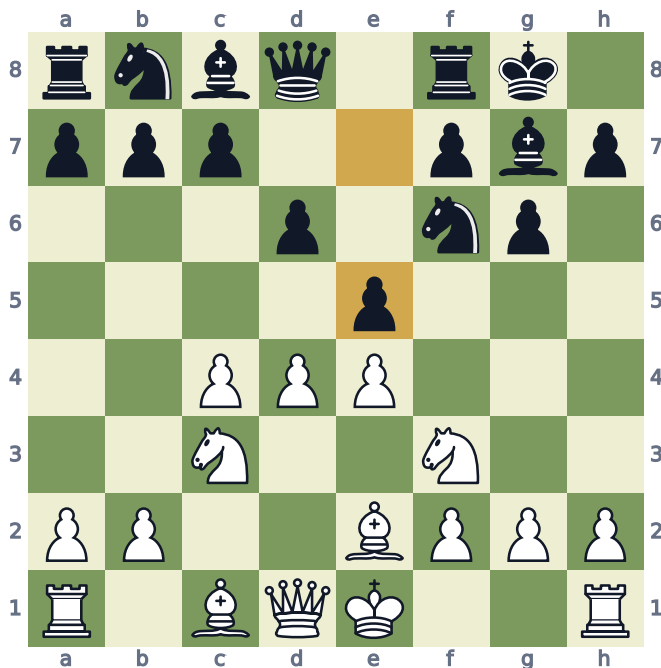
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7



- e4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- Nf3: White reroutes a knight toward f3; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.
- Be2: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- e5: Black makes direct central contact and asks whether White will close, capture, or maintain tension.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

After d5 the center becomes a directional map: White normally expands on the queenside while Black prepares kingside play.

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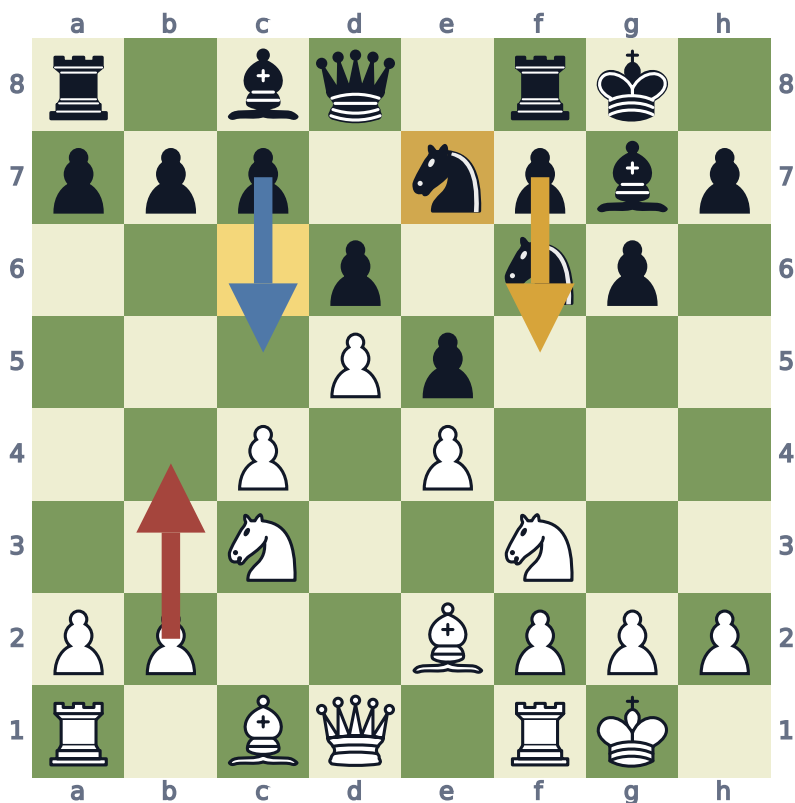
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The classical closed center



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

After d5 the center becomes a directional map: White normally expands on the queenside while Black prepares kingside play.

DECISION RULE

Compare the speed of ...f5 with White's c5 break and change plans if the center can reopen.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

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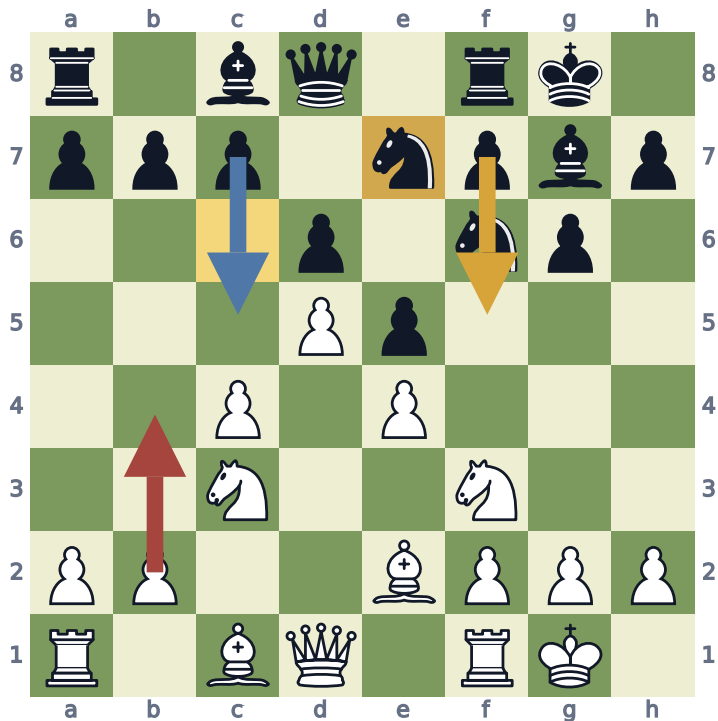
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The plan map



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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

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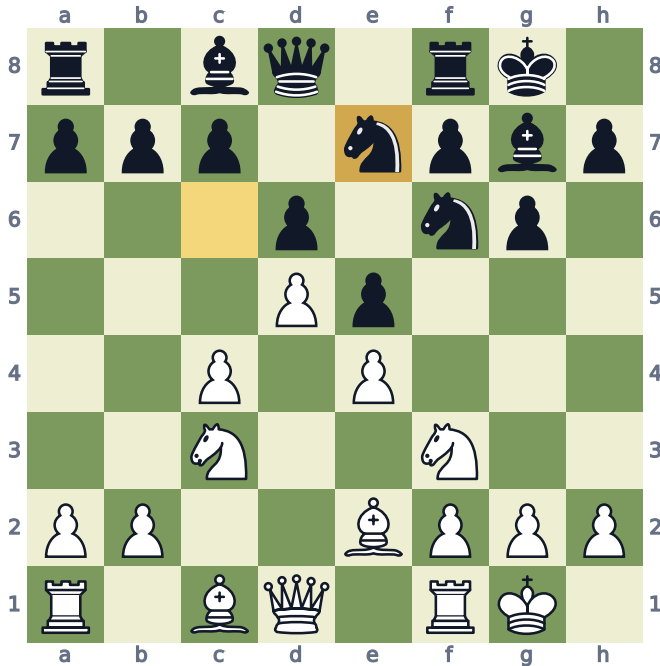
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7



- Be2: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- e5: Black makes direct central contact and asks whether White will close, capture, or maintain tension.
- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight toward c6; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- d5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- Ne7: Black reroutes a knight toward e7; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

After d5 the center becomes a directional map: White normally expands on the queenside while Black prepares kingside play.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Compare the speed of ...f5 with White's c5 break and change plans if the center can reopen. White's resistance is: White seeks c5, b4, and pressure against c7 or d6. The line fails as a template when: A kingside pawn storm is unsound when White can open the center against Black's king first.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

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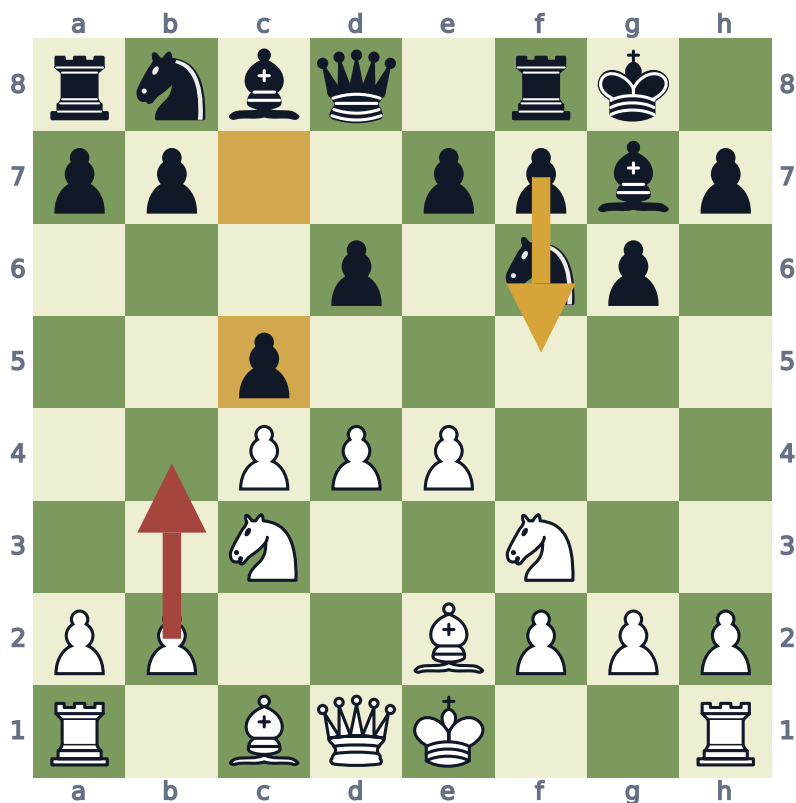
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The flank challenge with c5



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

The ...c5 system attacks d4 from the flank and often produces Benoni-like structures rather than a locked Mar del Plata.

DECISION RULE

Once ...c5 and ...e6 change the skeleton, stop using automatic closed-center attacking rules.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Pressure e4 and d5, use the e-file, and seek ...b5 or ...Nbd7 according to White's setup.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses the space advantage, e4-e5 possibilities, and queenside majority.

MEMORY RULE | Name the resulting structure before choosing the plan.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White uses the space advantage, e4-e5 possibilities, and queenside majority.

FAILURE MODE

Playing ...f5 by habit can weaken e6 and the king before the pieces are ready.

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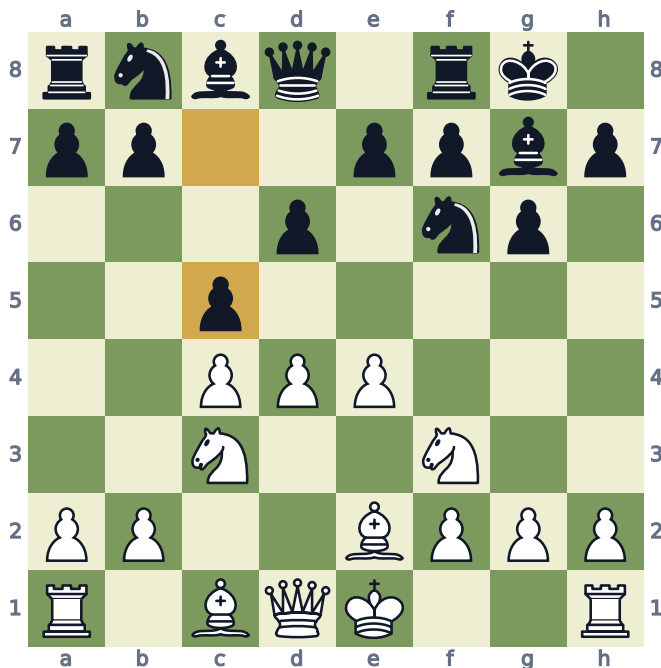
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 c5 7. d5 e6 8. O-O exd5 9. cxd5 Re8



- e4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- Nf3: White reroutes a knight toward f3; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.
- Be2: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- c5: Black attacks the center from the flank and invites a Benoni-like transformation.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

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WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

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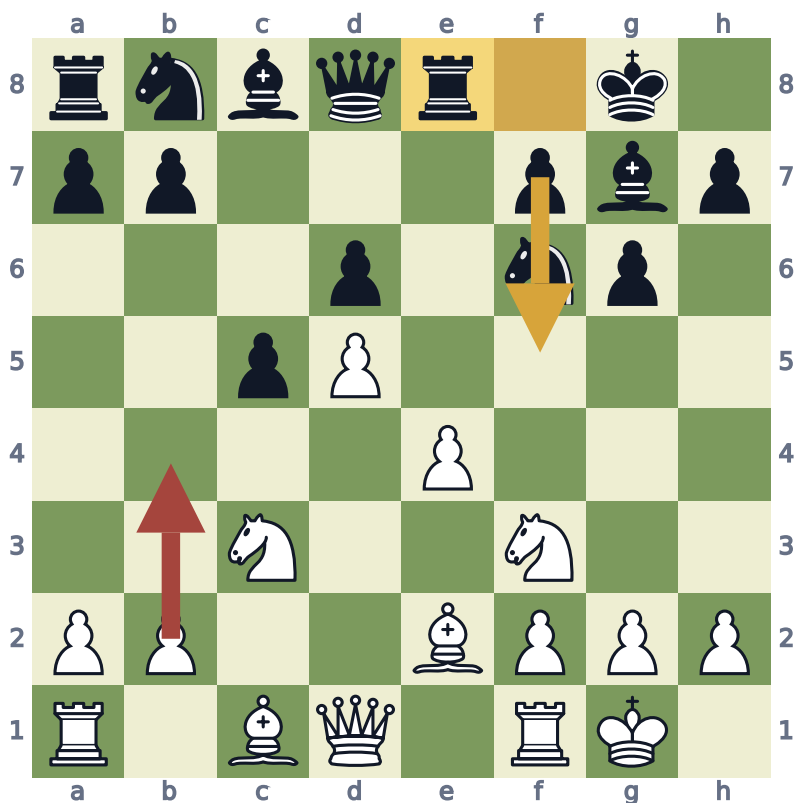
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 c5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The flank challenge with c5



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WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses the space advantage, e4-e5 possibilities, and queenside majority.

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1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 c5 7. d5 e6 8. O-O exd5 9. cxd5 Re8



- d5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- e6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.
- exd5: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- cxd5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- Re8: Black places a rook on a line expected to open or uses it to support a central transformation.

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5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. The ...c5 system attacks d4 from the flank and often produces Benoni-like structures rather than a locked Mar del Plata. 2. Pressure e4 and d5, use the e-file, and seek ...b5 or ...Nbd7 according to White's setup. 3. White uses the space advantage, e4-e5 possibilities, and queenside majority. 4. Once ...c5 and ...e6 change the skeleton, stop using automatic closed-center attacking rules. 5. Playing ...f5 by habit can weaken e6 and the king before the pieces are ready.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. d5 e6 8. O-O exd5 9. cxd5 Re8

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 001 Decode: The compact shell

Prompt: Decide whether the next useful act is ...e5, ...c5, or a preparation that makes one break sound.

Recall: The shell is only the launch platform; the break is the opening.

LESSON 002 Play: The compact shell

Prompt: Decide whether the next useful act is ...e5, ...c5, or a preparation that makes one break sound.

Recall: The shell is only the launch platform; the break is the opening.

LESSON 003 Decode: The classical closed center

Prompt: Compare the speed of ...f5 with White's c5 break and change plans if the center can reopen.

Recall: Closed chains point the wings, but tempi decide the race.

LESSON 004 Play: The classical closed center

Prompt: Compare the speed of ...f5 with White's c5 break and change plans if the center can reopen.

Recall: Closed chains point the wings, but tempi decide the race.

LESSON 005 Decode: The flank challenge with c5

Prompt: Once ...c5 and ...e6 change the skeleton, stop using automatic closed-center attacking rules.

Recall: Name the resulting structure before choosing the plan.

LESSON 006 Play: The flank challenge with c5

Prompt: Once ...c5 and ...e6 change the skeleton, stop using automatic closed-center attacking rules.

Recall: Name the resulting structure before choosing the plan.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's counterplay, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

The compact shell

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2

Decision: Decide whether the next useful act is ...e5, ...c5, or a preparation that makes one break sound.

Memory: The shell is only the launch platform; the break is the opening.

CARD 2

The classical closed center

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7

Decision: Compare the speed of ...f5 with White's c5 break and change plans if the center can reopen.

Memory: Closed chains point the wings, but tempi decide the race.

CARD 3

The flank challenge with c5

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 c5 7. d5 e6 8. O-O exd5 9. cxd5 Re8

Decision: Once ...c5 and ...e6 change the skeleton, stop using automatic closed-center attacking rules.

Memory: Name the resulting structure before choosing the plan.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
001 Decode: The compact shell	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
002 Play: The compact shell	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
003 Decode: The classical closed center	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
004 Play: The classical closed center	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
005 Decode: The flank challenge with c5	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
006 Play: The flank challenge with c5	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name White's best counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.